Burners Referee Guide

How the world pushes back. The players say what they do; this is the toolkit for everything they do it to — the passage of time, the dark closing in, and the first cold look of a stranger.

Three things run most of it: the Heat gauge you drive up and down as the scene's pressure, the Turn Tracker that keeps the world's ten-minute clock honest (old-school d6 for wandering monsters, light and noise on paper), and the Reaction roll that decides how the living things take to the crew.

Running Heat

Heat is the crew's shared **collateral** and the spine of every scene — the full player rules are in [[Burners Adventure Game]]; here is how you drive it. Unpaid Risk is always Heat. Bank it now; spend it when the mess comes back to bite — as scene pressure, or convert Heat into HP when the bite is on a body. You narrate the room tightening and the number, face-up on the table, tracks it.

Open every scene at a base, set by how hot the room already is:

Base	The scene
3–4	Quiet — a meet, a market, an empty road
6	Working — the vault, the wilderness, the parley that matters
8	Loud — the job blown, the chase, the hall on fire

Feed it. Every shortfall the crew can't soak raises Heat by what they fell short — compress big misses, a botched sneak is +1 or +2, not +5. A blow past a defense, a blown roll, a hard parley all feed it, and you may raise it by fiat when fresh danger walks in (reinforcements, a lit lantern, the storm arriving), announced. Wounds do not feed Heat; they carry their own pressure.

Telegraph threats to set the room. Rough rubric: raise Heat toward the shown monster's **HD** — lower if the foe is disadvantaged, higher if it owns the situation. Reveal in stages and the gauge climbs with the fiction — spoor, then half-eaten kills, then the beast at full HD (a pack: summed HD, capped by chokepoints and the dark). Show the signs for slow dread; conceal them for an ambush that raises no Heat and strikes with surprise on round 1 instead (surprised side dead last — [[Burners Adventure Game#Combat]]). Its presence sets the room; its attacks still quote its own Damage. Heat prices the situation — never the Monster Stack, never Initiative.

Work the valves. Heat falls when the crew acts on the room, not on request: fell or lose a named threat, −2; remove a named source (quench the fire, learn the ward-phrase), −1 or more; a Double Sweet vents 1; a steadying word or plan you buy, −1 once a scene. Folding ends the scene and cools to the next base. Downtime — a safe camp, a town between jobs — cools to base; a job that ended loud raises the base of what follows until the crew lies low and spends coin. Carousing is maintenance, not vice.

Heat is collateral and unpaid Risk, not the enemy Initiative dish. Foes roll a **group 1d6** for order (see *Monsters at speed*). Optional press remains a Referee call when a quote should bite harder — it does not require rolling Heat as a Fuel pool. Finish it or fold.

Hostile magic outside a fight

Burners has no spell save. In a fight, a Burner **Defends** the cast total with Fuel; overrun lands harm or control ([[Burners Sorcerie]]). Ordinary folk and monsters at preferred speed have no Fuel — they do not get a free Defend.

Out of combat the working lands. The caster rolls `2d6 + Sorcerie` (Craft for Canting) against your Risk. Shortfall is Heat — collateral (and noise, time, or a Spicy twist when that fits). Bank it and spend when it bites.

Friendly conversation. Control and charm aimed at a willing talker — *Bewitch*, *Command*, *Charm Person* from a module — may be cast without starting combat and without rolling Initiative. The mark is charmed (or obeys the word) as the spell says. Spell fiction still holds: no suicidal orders, habits and duty can balk, a friend still will not open the vault.

Otherwise, roll Initiative. Ambush, argument going hot, steel already out, the mark already suspicious — the working is an opening blow. Roll Initiative; Burners Defend; preferred-speed monsters still do not. The caster gains no free first strike.

Spend Heat on the charm's aftermath. Someone noticed (another guard, a townsman). The hold is thin — breaks tomorrow, or at the next watch change. When it lifts, the mark wants justice or revenge. Duration, witnesses, and later heat are your spend; do not ask for a second save.

Worked table rulings for every 1st-level spell: [[Burners Magic Examples]].

Running the Delve

The exploration turn is one Turn — ten minutes. Each turn runs the same short loop:

1. **Declare.** The party sets a pace (cautious, normal, or hurried) and a primary action for the turn — move, search, listen, force, rest, interact, or something else.

2. **Present the Scene.** Frame the place in three strokes — Scene, Oddity, Risk (below). One vivid image, one thing that begs to be poked, one reason to hesitate.

3. **Resolve.** Play out the action: movement, searching, talk, a forced door, a fight.

4. **Advance the clock.** Mark the Turn on the Turn Tracker (below). Tick light. Check for wandering monsters when the schedule or a bang calls for it. Update ongoing spells, conditions, and any other clocks the fiction demands.

Between turns the loop just repeats: frame, resolve, advance.

Searching and Traps

Searching costs a Turn. What it buys depends on what they tell you they are doing.

1. **Intent and method.** "We search the room" is a Turn spent and a rough look. "I run my knife along the seam under the sill" is a specific act on a specific thing, and it gets a specific answer.
2. **Give the information.** Anything a careful person would notice in ten minutes, they notice — no roll. The scratched flagstone, the draft, the tool marks, the chest whose lid sits a finger too high. You are not hiding facts; you are charging time for them.

3. **Roll only if it is still uncertain.** When the method might work and might not, it is `2d6 + Craft` vs the Risk. When the method plainly works on that problem, it works. When it plainly does not — bare hands on a masterwork lock — say so and let them spend the Turn elsewhere.

A trap the party has been told about is a puzzle, not a gotcha (see [[Burners Principles#No gotchas]]). Spring it undetected only when they walked past the sign or never looked. The trap quotes flat Damage — no Fuel up out of combat; armor soaks, rest to HP.

Mark the Turn either way. A fruitless search still burns light and still feeds the wandering-monster schedule.

Scene, Oddity, Risk

Every room, encounter, or travel scene should answer three questions. Build it in thirty seconds and it will run itself.

Scene — what do they immediately perceive? One or two sentences, no backstory: one memorable image and one dominant sense. The players should instantly know where they are.

Oddity — what invites investigation? More than something strange: something that begs to be touched, examined, talked to, experimented with, circumvented, or asked about. The players should think "what's going on here?" If they can ignore it without a second thought, it is not a strong enough oddity.

Risk — what makes that investigation uncertain? Every interesting choice carries a possible cost: monsters, traps, hazards, time pressure, noise, resource drain, social fallout, a moral bind. The risk need not trigger at once, but it must be real. The players should think "how do we approach this?"

The test. If a scene has no curiosity, no meaningful interaction, and no consequence, it is just scenery — rewrite it. Run the checklist: can I picture it? do I want to investigate it? do I hesitate before I do? Three yeses and the scene is ready.

Example — Scene: a rope bridge spans a mist-filled chasm. Oddity: every rope has been cleanly cut, yet the bridge still hangs in the air. Risk: crossing or closely examining it wakes whatever holds it aloft.

Turn Tracker

A world Turn is ten minutes. Track Turns on paper where the players can see it. Number them **1 through 6**, then wrap back to **1** — six Turns is an hour, and a torch burns exactly one cycle. Even turns (2, 4, 6) are when the schedule comes round; the count itself tells you, so write nothing for the check. A bare check mark works too if you prefer not to count. Write noise if they made any — `!` for noise, `!!` for extra noise. Shouting, kicking in doors, fighting, casting spells, and the like all count. Note light and what happened.

The paper holds what the characters themselves know: time spent, noise made, light burning low, and what they did with the Turn. It is a log of the delve, not a record of your procedure.

When the count wraps, an hour has passed — a torch is spent, a lantern marks one of its four. Mark the wrap in the margin if you like (`h2`, `h3`) so absolute delve length stays visible without an endless turn count. There is no required rest Turn. If the crew wants to recover HP, that is an [[Burners Adventure Game#Wounds|Hour Rest]]: a full cycle spent quiet, with food and water, and no Wound on the Burner who rests. Even turns still fire during a rest hour unless the place is truly safe.

```
1  enter, listen at the door
2  Bellamy lantern lit (24)
3 ! forced the grate — the screech carries
4  long hall, water dripping somewhere ahead
```

```
5  search the shrine
6 !! fight in the nave · lantern out
— hour —
1  bind wounds in the dark
2  feeling along the north wall
```

Wandering monsters (1-in-6)

Every check is the same: roll **1d6**, and a **1** finds something. What changes is **how often** you roll. Each signature is a reason to pick up the die:

- **Time** — even turns (2, 4, 6); the dungeon breathing
- **Noise** — when you write `!` or `!!`; roll now
- **Dark** — when light fails; roll now
- **Wounds** — when a fight ends and someone is Wounded; roll now

So on turn 2 you roll once for time. If they then yell, you roll again for noise — another 1-in-6, not a bigger pool. A bloody scrap in the dark that ends with the lantern dead can throw three or four dice across the beat, each its own 1-in-6. The chance never climbs past "one in six"; the crew just hears the die more often.

One roll per trigger. A bang on an even turn is two rolls (time, then noise), not one combined pool.

Write nothing for the check. The turn number already tells you when the schedule comes round, and a bang is its own reminder — so the paper never has to say "the dungeon rolled for you." What the players get is the sound of the die and, when it lands, something coming down the hall. If you want the moment on the log, write what the place did — *water stops dripping*, *a door closes two rooms off* — not that you checked.

When an encounter lands, set distance and warning from the fiction (or the module), roll Reaction if the thing can parley, and build it per Building and Running Monsters (below).

Whatever comes was already doing something before the dice said so. Say what in one breath — patrolling, hunting, hauling a kill, fleeing something worse, arguing over spoils, lost. That one line turns a roll into a clue about the place, and it usually tells you the Reaction before you roll it.

Light

Track burn on the paper — do not hide it behind a die.

- **Torch:** 30′ for 1 hour — one full cycle (6 Turns). Bundle of 6: 1 gp, 1 slot ([[Burners Equipment]]).
- **Lantern:** 30′ for 4 hours (24 Turns / four cycles) per flask. Lantern 10 gp; oil 2 gp; 1 slot each.
- **Candle:** 5′ for 1 hour — one cycle. Bundle of 6: 1 gp, 1 slot.
- **Rag-on-a-stick:** as candle, up to ~20 minutes if lucky. Free, 1 slot.

The Grind — Supplies, Fatigue

Light lives on the Turn Tracker. Fatigue is why the party cannot crawl forever, and it needs no separate die — it feeds Heat, because Heat is the crew's shared wind and nerve, and wearing down a long crawl is exactly the loss of those. When the fiction calls for a grind tick (long haul, thin air, lingering too long), raise the gauge, usually +1, and it rides there until the crew vents it. **Ammunition, holy water, incendiaries, and rations** are counted on the sheet — mark each when spent ([[Burners Equipment#Count these]]). Do not hand-wave those four. An Hour Rest on the tracker (a full quiet cycle with food and water) is how unwounded Burners fill HP — see [[Burners Adventure Game#Wounds]] — not a tax for failing to sit every hour.

A Journeyman keeps the band fresh. The [[Burners Adventure Game|Journeyman's craft]] reduces party-wide travel, weather, and survival costs by the Journeyman's Craft level, and fatigue in the dark is a survival cost like any other. Subtract the Journeyman's Craft from the tick for everyone they are leading: Craft 1 shrugs off a routine +1 entirely. Fatigue bites when the party has no Journeyman, when the Journeyman is down or split off from the group, or when the place is harsh enough to outrun their level. Scale the tick to the dungeon — a mild crawl adds 1, a brutal one (heat, thin air, crushing dark) adds 2 or 3, so a Journeyman's Craft matters more the worse the ground gets.

The over-extended party is the danger this builds: the grind pushes Heat up even when nothing is attacking, so a crew that lingers, lost and tired, walks into the next fight against a hotter scene — Risks bite harder and optional presses hit harder. "We're worn thin and the room's boiling, and nothing's even swung at us yet — we have to get out" is the pressure a long crawl builds even when nobody has taken a wound.

Cooling off — and how HP comes back

Heat cools when the crew acts on the room (see Running Heat). HP and Wounds follow [[Burners Adventure Game#Wounds]]:

- **Full HP closes wounds.**
- **Hour Rest** (one hour, food and water) fills HP to maximum **only if you have no Wound**.
- **Wounded: 1 HP per day** with food until full, then the Wound closes. Vitae / *Stanch* / potions can help; *Healing Touch* does not restore at 0 HP or less.
- **First aid** (Craft) tends a wound and can be the **help** for the post-fight survival check; it does not restore HP by itself.
- After a fight where you took a Wound: **help**, then **`2d6 + Craft` vs severity** — or die. Monster specials (spawn, etc.) if you die from that creature's attack.

Classic Crawl (optional campaign flavor): once unwounded and at 0+, use **1d3 HP per full day** in a safe haven instead of Hour Rest for luck recovery. Write the choice at session zero. Wounds and survival still run as above.

Undead

Player rules: [[Burners Burn Undead]].

Undead. They have unnatural senses that can find the living — they do not rely on eyes or ears. Some can be driven back by fire (husks that fear it recoil from a brand; the brand is the right tool; willful undead do not). They do not die unless purged in fire — Cracked or emptied stacks get back up if you leave the bones. Anyone slain by undead rises as undead unless you burn their bones.

Damage. Damage inflicted by undead does not come back with Hour Rest or the day's climb. Magical healing, or Purge. A 3 HP nick stays gone; a 3-point undead Wound will not close with sleep.

Purge: spend one Incendiary. You gain a Wound equal to the hit points of damage you are purging — 5 HP lost, purged, is a 5-point burn Wound. Survival as after any Wound. Live: the taint is gone (the burn is an ordinary Wound). Die of the fyre: rest, no spawn.

Midnight: any Wound inflicted by undead worsens by `1d6` + HD (skeleton `1d6+1`, zombie `1d6+2`, wight `1d6+3`). Immediate Survival (`2d6 + Craft` vs severity, helped if a friend holds you). Fail, or alone → die. Die unclean → spawn.

Herrick has 3 HP and gambeson (AC 2). A barrow-wight (HD 3) hits him for 5; he burns nothing; leftover 5, gambeson soaks 2; he drops to 0 — luck spent, no Wound, 3 HP stolen. Hour Rest will not fill him. A potion would. Or they purge: 3-point burn Wound, Survival vs 3. Live: ordinary Wound. Next blow is 9, leftover 9, soak 2, he goes to −4: undead Wound, severity 4. Shock, then help after the fight, survival holds. Still unclean. At midnight it worsens by `1d6+3`, then Survival — or they purge him first. Die unclean and he rises. Die of the purge and he rests.

No level loss on touch unless you prefer it. Run OSE undead as written; overlays: [[Burners OSE Conversions#Undead]].

Reaction — First Impressions

Disposition is a fact of the world (see Influence in [[Burners Adventure Game|the core rules]]), and when it is not already fixed by the fiction you roll for it. Any NPC, monster, or faction the party meets fresh gets a Reaction: roll 2d6 and read the table. This is the world's own leaning at first contact — the roll only says how it starts; what you ask next is still the Two Steps.

Circumstances are the main lever. A drawn blade, a shared enemy, a debt, a standing feud, or a fearsome reputation shift the roll the way a situational modifier shifts a defend — set a plus or minus from the same bands. Where one character is plainly making the approach (the spokesperson, the one who speaks the tongue, the face of the band), add their Heart. And Sweet and Spicy ride along as always: a rolled 6 is a good twist on the meeting, a rolled 1 a complication, whatever the total.

2d6	Reaction	What it means
2 or less	Hostile	It moves against you now: attack, alarm, or bolt into a worse response. A natural 2 (fumble) is always Hostile.
3–5	Wary	Suspicion, hard words, steep terms. It would rather you were gone; push it and it turns.
6–8	Neutral	Uncertain and cautious, no commitment either way — the most open to being swayed by what you do next.
9–11	Amiable	Warm enough to talk, trade, or lend a hand, for a fair price or a good reason.
12 or more	Friendly	It takes a shine to you: real aid, a favor, the start of an ally. A natural 12 (perfect) is always Friendly.

Roll once at first meeting. Re-roll only when something material changes the footing: they save its life, they are caught in a lie, the faction hears what they did in the last town. A creature with no capacity for parley — mindless undead, a beast in a killing frenzy, a construct bound to its orders — skips the roll and does what its nature dictates; the table is for anything that can, in principle, be dealt with.

Reaction sets the starting disposition; the Two Steps and Influence carry the specific asks from there. A Friendly guard still will not hand you the keys to the vault, but he might look the other way where a Hostile one raises the cry.

Frequency — running hot or cool

The default Turn Tracker (count 1–6 and wrap, a check on even turns, plus a roll whenever noise, dark, or wounds fire) is classic dungeon tempo. Loud, dark, bloody crawls hear the die more often and feel the pressure. If a job should run hotter, check every turn. If cooler, only bang-check on `!!`.

Delve Die (optional)

If you want one 2d6 to fold encounter, break, and grind into a single roll, use this instead of the d6 WM checks — not both.

Roll 2d6, add nothing. Read the 1s and the 6s, not the sum.

- Any **1** → encounter. The other die is lead time (1,1 surprise through 1,6 distant drop).
- A **6** and no 1 → a break (safe nook, shortcut, omen, cache). Double 6 is a real gift.
- Neither → the grind: tick light, supplies, or fatigue (see The Grind above).

Every Turn runs hot; every other Turn is cooler. Distant 1,5 / 1,6 can be a sighting the party slips away from.

Building and Running Monsters

A monster is any enemy: Hit Dice, an armor equivalent, attacks, and a public **Monster Stack** of **2 × HD** playing cards. Its Hit Dice are its level: most humans are 0, most orcs are 1, a veteran higher. How blows land on that stack: this section. Burner-side Fuel economy: [[Burners Principles#Pools, not fixed numbers]].

Monsters at speed (preferred Referee mode)

Monsters have Hit Dice. Deal each monster a **Monster Stack** of **2 × HD** playing cards. Ignore rank and suit. The stack replaces notepad HP. Players like a fat Fuel pool; you keep the enemy side **small and quotable**.

Initiative. Each distinct enemy group rolls **1d6** every Round Initiative (reroll each round; no declare-before-roll). Shambling / acts last as written — skip the die, go last. Round 1 surprise: a surprised side is dead last that round (Fuel and Actions unchanged). PC Initiative stays the count of 3s and 4s on Fuel — [[Burners Adventure Game#Combat]]. Win the number and the whole Action is theirs then. A Burner may hold any of it for a trigger; when a held attack and a foe's go off together, more weapon slots strikes first, and same slots land together — [[Burners Adventure Game#Combat]].

Free attack (quote). Flat damage — no die from an Init pool.

Fiction	Quote
Light (dagger, claw d4)	**2**
Common (sword, claw d6, tentacle+cutlass)	**2** or **3**
Heavy (d8, axe, crab smash)	**4**
Huge (d10+, ogre, polearm-beast)	**5**

Grab / constrict. Printed grab, pincer, coil: see **Constrict** in [[Burners Adventure Game#Combat]].

Armor. Every monster has an **armor equivalent** on the same ladder as Burners' armor, natural armor included. Tell the players. Say it the first time steel meets the thing, in the world's words with the number: *"Your blade skids off scales like a mail shirt. AC 3."* Then leave it on the index card by the stack. The players do the math; you flip cards.

Take it from the monster's D&D armor class, or just say what it looks like.

AC	As	D&D AC	For example
0	Bare	9–8 [10–11]	Townsfolk, zombie, gelatinous cube

AC	As	D&D AC	For example
1	Leather	7 [12]	Skeleton, wolf, boar, giant rat
2	Gambeson	6 [13]	Goblin, orc, bear, minotaur
3	Mail	5–4 [14–15]	Man-at-arms, ogre, gnoll, troll
4	Plate	3 [16]	Wyvern, white dragon, knight in plate
5	Full plate	2 [17] or better	Giant crab, red dragon, the knight's lord

One blow:

1. Compare the weapon's **slots** to the monster's **AC**. Slots higher: **+2** damage. Equal: nothing. Slots lower: **−2** damage.
2. Divide by 5. With the weapon's **Trait**, round up; without it, round down. Zero or less bounces.
3. Pop that many cards.

Damage	Hits with the Trait	Hits without
1–4	1	0
5	1	1
6–9	2	1
10	2	2
11–14	3	2
15	3	3
16–19	4	3

A sword (2 slots) against a goblin (AC 2): even. A blow of 4 is one card with the sword Trait, and bounces without it. Against a troll (AC 3) the sword is lower: 4 is 2, one card trained, nothing untrained. A greatsword (4) against the troll: 5 and 4 is 9, +2 is 11, three cards.

Resistances use the same step. A monster's stat line can fix the result of the comparison for named weapons, tags, or stuff, whatever their slots. Write them down before play so nobody argues them mid-fight, and tell the players the first time one shows, the same as the AC.

- **Resistances:** always −2 against what's named, or −4 for what barely touches it. A skeleton resists Cutty weapons (−2), and arrows rattle through its empty ribs (−4); a mace still compares as usual, 2 slots against AC 1, +2.
- **Bane:** always +2. Silver for the werewolf, fire for the troll.

Skeleton: AC 1, 1 HD (2 cards). Cutty −2, arrows −4.

Dead = stack empty; scoop.

Tactics: the right weapon for the foe is the players' call, and they can see the numbers. Hand the big steel to whoever can reach; Block with the shield while it works. A sword against a troll's mail is lower, so even a trained hand only chips at it; untrained, it does nothing.

Press (optional). When a quote should bite harder, add one of the Referee's dice to it or bump by fiat — not a Heat Initiative pool.

Hordes. Shared group d6 for the knot. Attacks = bodies in reach. One **Monster Stack** (2 × HD cards) per body; their kit only sets the AC. Fat stacks for solos and named threats.

Shambling → act last.

Full-dice monsters (optional). Solo duel / demo as a Burner for spend and Defend. **Initiative stays group (or solo) 1d6** — do not switch order to a 3/4 Fuel count. Default is speed mode.

The Referee's dice

When the fight starts, roll a small handful of dice face-up. They are your dice for the whole fight: spent dice are gone, and they do not refill at Round Initiative. You pick how many. A good default is the Hit Dice of the biggest monster in the room or one per player, whichever is greater: an ogre of HD 4 against three players is four dice; a knot of orcs against five players is five.

They put some chance into the fight so it doesn't run like clockwork. Add one to a quote to press it, or burn a 6 to get a foe past the line, rarely (see *Line of attack*). Because they never refill, the 6s stay scarce.

They are not a Fuel pool. Monsters don't Defend with them, and they don't decide who goes first: each foe group still rolls its 1d6 every round. Don't try to match the Burners die for die. The players should come away feeling clever, and the monsters are not as clever.

Morale — when the other side quits

Scores port from OSE unchanged (2–12, rolled on 2d6, roll under the score to hold). What matters at the table is remembering to ask. Check at these moments, once each:

- the side takes its **first death**
- the side is down to **half** its bodies, or a solo to half its cards
- the **leader** falls, flees, or is plainly beaten
- something lands that the creature has no answer to — fire on a beast, silver on the thing silver is for, a working it cannot shake

A failed check is not always flight. Read it off the fiction: run, surrender, bargain, drop the loot and scatter, or fall back to a defensible spot and keep watching. Animals bolt; disciplined troops withdraw in order; the desperate beg. Mindless things — husks, constructs, a beast in frenzy — skip Morale entirely and fight to the last card, which is exactly what makes them frightening.

When a side breaks, the threat is overcome for Heat purposes even if the bodies are still on the table. Vent, then decide whether the party gives chase (see Retreat and Pursuit).

Situational Damage Modifiers

The Referee raises or lowers Damage for the situation. Set a value from the band, or roll a swing die when the moment is chaotic. Narrate the cause so players can attack the reason.

Band	Feel	Examples
+1	slight edge	bad footing, downhill, a mild distraction
+2	clear advantage	from behind, flanked, foe in the dirt, grappled
+3	strong	surprised, blinded, struck mid-cast

Band	Feel	Examples
+4	severe	pinned, ambushed in the dark, several stacked
+5	dire	helpless while the fight still rages

Cover is not a Damage cut — it is the missile Defend cap (1 die normally, 2 with Cover). See [[Burners Adventure Game]]. When a blow outruns the dice a defender can burn plus their armor, the excess lands on HP — and past 0 it opens a Wound.

Swarms

Foes piling onto one target attack like a single Veteran of many levels: the group makes a bundle of attacks — reckon one per body in reach, or one per Hit Die for a larger creature — each its own blow of up to two dice, each defended separately, leftover then soaked by the defender's armor. Three orcs on Aldric are three attacks, not one big one. Once Aldric has meleed this round he Defends without limit against all of them; until then each blow is one die. **Block**, **Counterattack**, and mid-tempo disrupt: [[Burners Adventure Game]]. A chokepoint caps how many reach you at once; kill one and the bundle loses its attacks.

Keeping the blows separate is deliberate. A single combined Damage would blow past armor in one unsoakable spike; many small hits, each Defended and then soaked, mean a mob wears you down through attrition and a draining Fuel pool instead — you run out of dice to defend before you run out of HP. That is the real danger of numbers: not one dreadful blow, but more attacks than you have dice to answer. The counter is avoidance — break line of sight, fight from a chokepoint, raise a shield as Cover, or thin the mob until the swings come slower than you can turn them.

Retreat and Pursuit

Running is a real option and it needs a real procedure, or the table will fight to the death out of habit. When the crew calls a retreat, work it in this order.

Name the destination. Not "we run" — *where*. The stair, the spiked door two rooms back, the coal chute, daylight. If they cannot name it, they do not know the way out, and that is the answer.

Take the roles. Someone leads (they know the route), someone holds the rear (one Burner at a chokepoint buys the rest a beat), and someone carries what is being carried. A body cannot do two of these.

Name the price. Retreat always costs something, said out loud before the dice: the strongbox left behind, a dropped torch, a lantern that gutters, the wounded man's pace, the door they cannot spike in time. Let them choose which cost they pay when there is a choice.

Then the pursuers. Not everything follows. Ask what the thing wants. Territorial beasts stop at the border; scavengers stop at the dropped food or the dropped gold; hunters follow while the trail is loud; the truly relentless follow until stopped. State the stop condition first, then let the crew try to meet it — bar the door, drop the meat, kill the light, go quiet.

Kit earns its slots here. **Spikes and wedges** turn a door into a clock; **oil** turns a corridor into a wall; **caltrops and dropped coin** buy beats from the greedy; going dark buys everything if the pursuer hunts by sight. A retreat that spends gear and light is a good retreat, not a failure.

Mark the Turn, and mark it loud — a flight is `!!` on the tracker. Heat does not vent for running; it vents when the threat is behind them and the door is shut.

Line of attack

Fuel is rolled face-up. Everyone can see the 6s.

An attack hits the first one in its line, friend or foe, unless a 6 is burned on it (see *Line of attack* in [[Burners Adventure Game]]). A shot past your own front rank hits a friend; a shot at the enemy archer behind their shield wall hits the shield wall. That is the rule working as written, not a gotcha to spring cold.

Before the arrow goes: give a friendly warning. *"Are you sure? Aldric's in the line, and you've got no 6."* The player still chooses. You telegraphed the risk while the dice were already on the table. See [[Burners Principles#No gotchas]].

Foes can get past the line too, on a 6 among your dice (see *The Referee's dice*), but rarely, and only when you choose. Getting past the line is the players' trick. Burners behind their front line should feel safe there, and a foe that picks off the back rank every round makes the front line pointless.

Coming Back — Restocking

A place the party left is not a place on pause. When they return, the dungeon has reacted; it has not reset. Cleared rooms stay cleared and hard-won ground stays won — but the site answers what was done to it. Ask four questions and change only what they touch.

Who survived, and what did they learn? The ones who lived move the treasure, post a watch on the way the party came in, block the coal chute, or bring in help. A crew that fought loud at the entry stair finds the entry stair guarded.

Who moved in? Cleared space does not stay empty long. Something smaller creeps up from below, something larger claims the good room, scavengers work the corpses the party left. The new tenant is usually weaker than what was killed — the place is diminished, not restored.

What pressure advanced? Whatever the site was doing while nobody watched — a ritual further along, water risen another foot, a fungus spread down the hall, a faction's dig deeper. One thing, not five.

What scars show? The spiked door still bears its spikes. The burned hall still stinks. The bodies are gone but the stains are not. Show one piece of their own work back to them; it is the cheapest way to make the world feel remembered.

How much changes rides on how long they were gone and how loudly they left. A day or two and a quiet exit: watches posted, little else. A week and a bloody exit: new tenants, moved treasure, and someone hunting the crew by name. Between jobs a loud site raises the base Heat of the next visit until the crew lies low (see Running Heat).

Do this at the door, not room by room. Three lines in your notes before the session is the whole procedure.

The Safe Town

The party begins in a safe town, which is a haven but not a home base and not theirs. It offers lodging, food, supplies, law, healing, and rumors: a place to cool off, re-equip, mend wounds, and hear where trouble lies. The party are guests on someone else's ground, and the town has its own authorities and life. Adventures spiral out from it and back to it, and a party may later earn or build a true home base of their own.

Level on a safe sleep. XP banks in the field; characters take a level when they next sleep somewhere safe — town, inn, watched camp — after their total crosses a tier and they hold the four Traits. Not in the press. Rare emergencies are your call. See [[Burners Experience]].

XP tracking. Treasure wrested from the dungeon (credited at the deed) and monsters overcome only — [[Burners Experience]]. Monster parts, kit, and bounties are purse or gear, never XP. Keep totals behind the screen: when a Burner with four Traits and enough XP wakes from a safe sleep, tell the player they level up. Keep the fight-and-deed roster and the master treasure list (what each foe guards, who it was credited to) in your notes.

Inventing spells and items. When a player wants a working or lasting item not in the catalog, treat it as a campaign project: time, rare materials, a teacher or ruin, and a clear failure mode. No price table. Costume Arcana is shop gear at 100 gp; enchanted Arcana stays a find. Research may yield a scroll or potion formula, or a one-off the table invents together. See [[Burners Sorcerie]].

Enemy true writings. When a foe casts from a tradition (or keeps a library), stock **true writings** as treasure on purpose: each is **one named spell**, school labeled (or common Sorcerie). One to three finds is plenty. Scrolls are optional spice. A dead mage's **personal spellbook** is crib notation — it does not teach the party. A dragon still needs a Breath telegraph more than a book — this habit is for wizard-type foes and libraries.

Pricing Unlisted Gear

When an item is not on the [[Burners Equipment]] tables, price it from its slots and category, then adjust for quality and rarity and add it to the list. Listed gear uses the Equipment prices. The rates below are for **unlisted** pieces.

- Common gear (clothing, tools, a waterskin): 1 gp per slot.
- Fine steel and specialty goods (books, lockpicks, instruments, specialty tools): 10 gp per slot.
- Plain armaments (odd weapons not on the list): 5 gp per slot.
- Provisions: 1 gp per meal for the group.
- Ranged weapons and special materials such as silver add a surcharge when you invent a new piece.
- Costume Arcana: **100 gp apiece** in town; enchanted Arcana is found, seized, gifted, or inherited. Scrolls and potions are downtime craft at 100 gp × spell level (see [[Burners Sorcerie]]).
- **Ask a teacher to teach you something: 1,000 gp × spell level** — teacher chooses the working (see *Learning Spells* on [[Burners Sorcerie]]). Blank **personal spellbook**: **25 gp**.
- Heavy or exceptional armaments run far dearer: about 100 gp for a +1 grade, 1,000 gp for a rare +2 (added on a listed or formula price).
- Elevated quality adds to any item: +10 gp for fine, +100 for rich, +1,000 for noble work.
- Magic items are rarely for sale at any price; you decide whether one can be found at all. Stocking enchanted arms: [[Burners Referee Magic Items]].